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Executive Summary

Geopolitics in 2026 refers to the strategic competition among major states and blocs over technology, resources, trade routes, and institutional influence. The dominant frame among decision-makers centers on systemic rivalry between the United States and China, the restructuring of supply chains around security considerations, and the fragmentation of international governance institutions.

This brief documents how key actors are reasoning about geopolitical risk at this moment in time. It does not predict outcomes or recommend courses of action. Instead, it records the assumptions, frameworks, and

observed behaviors shaping decisions by governments, corporations, and multilateral organizations in early 2026.

Key themes include the securitization of technology and trade policy, the resilience imperative driving industrial policy, persistent tensions over Taiwan, energy transition geopolitics, and the weakening of multilateral consensus mechanisms. Decision-makers are operating under conditions of heightened strategic uncertainty, with risk mitigation increasingly prioritized over efficiency optimization.

Context Snapshot — Why This Matters Now

Geopolitical analysis has moved from peripheral risk consideration to central strategic planning across sectors. Several structural shifts underpin this transition.

The United States and China remain locked in strategic competition across technology, trade, and military domains. According to the U.S. Department of Defense's 2022 National Defense Strategy, China represents the "pacing challenge" for U.S. security planning (<https://media.defense.gov/2022/Oct/27/2003103845/-1/-1/1/2022-NATIONAL-DEFENSE-STRATEGY-NPR-MDR.PDF>). Export controls on advanced semiconductors, imposed by the U.S. Bureau of Industry and Security in October 2022 and expanded in 2023, reflect the integration of national security logic into technology governance (<https://www.bis.doc.gov/index.php/policy-guidance/federal-register-notice>).

The conflict in Ukraine, ongoing since February 2022, has accelerated discussions about energy security, sanctions architecture, and alliance structures. The European Union's REPowerEU plan, published in May 2022, committed member states to reducing dependency on Russian fossil fuels and diversifying supply chains (https://energy.ec.europa.eu/topics/energy-security/repower-eu_en).

Supply chain resilience has become a policy priority. The U.S. CHIPS and Science Act, enacted in August 2022, authorized \$52 billion in subsidies for domestic semiconductor manufacturing (<https://www.congress.gov/bills/117/congress/house/bills/4346>). The European Union's Critical Raw Materials Act, proposed in March 2023, aims to secure access to minerals essential for technology and energy transition (https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_23_1661).

Multilateral institutions face coordination challenges. The World Trade Organization has not concluded a major multilateral trade round since 1995, and its dispute settlement mechanism has been non-functional since December 2019 due to U.S. opposition to appellate body appointments (https://www.wto.org/english/tratop_e/dispute_e/appellate_body_e.htm).

Attention to Taiwan has intensified. Military exercises by the People's Liberation Army around Taiwan have increased in frequency and scale since August 2022, following then-U.S. House Speaker Nancy Pelosi's visit to Taipei (<https://www.defense.gov/News/Releases/>).

These developments inform current decision-making frameworks.

What Geopolitics Is (Plain English)

Geopolitics describes the relationship between geography, power, and strategy in international relations. It encompasses how states and other actors compete for influence, resources, and security across physical and institutional domains.

In practical terms, geopolitics involves the interaction of national interests, alliance structures, territorial disputes, control over critical infrastructure, access to strategic resources, and the rules governing international commerce and security.

Contemporary geopolitics extends beyond traditional military and territorial concerns. Technology standards, semiconductor supply chains, undersea cables, critical minerals, and digital infrastructure now feature prominently in strategic planning. The securitization of technology means that products, platforms, and capabilities previously treated as commercial matters are increasingly subject to national security evaluation.

Common misunderstandings include the assumption that geopolitics is purely military or that economic interdependence prevents conflict. Historical evidence suggests interdependence can coexist with strategic rivalry. Another misconception is that geopolitical risk is binary—either present or absent. In practice, decision-makers navigate degrees of risk, uncertainty, and exposure across multiple dimensions simultaneously.

Geopolitics does not imply inevitability of conflict. It describes the structure of competition and the constraints under which actors operate.

Dominant Frameworks in Use

Several analytical frameworks shape how institutions approach geopolitical risk in 2026.

The strategic competition framework treats major power relations as fundamentally competitive rather than cooperative. This lens, adopted widely across U.S. defense and foreign policy institutions, assumes that China seeks to displace U.S. influence in Asia and globally. The framework emphasizes military modernization, technology leadership, and alliance coordination. It informs defense planning, technology export controls, and investment screening mechanisms.

The resilience and diversification framework prioritizes supply chain security over cost optimization. Policymakers and corporate strategists use this approach to identify single points of failure, geographic concentration risks, and dependencies on potentially adversarial suppliers. The framework drives reshoring, nearshoring, and friendshoring initiatives. It underpins industrial policy measures in semiconductors, pharmaceuticals, and critical minerals.

The great power competition framework, used by defense and intelligence communities, views international relations as a contest among major states for regional and global dominance. This framework emphasizes